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I used to ask my mom all the time when I was a kid: What would happen to us if she and my dad died? (Sensing a morbid theme here?) I believe the game plan was for me to go live with my dad's sister and her husband, which worked for me. Their house was sweet, with its lush garden and big fish tank. I was down to move in, worst-case scenario. But now that I'm an adult, am I financially prepared in case my parents die?

Both of writer Eden Dranger's parents had passed away by the time she was in her early 20s. Her mother died first, and the funeral, she remembered, was expensive because her family wanted her mom buried in Israel. She had to fly there with her mother's dead body in storage underneath the plane. Even more terrifying than that nightmare was that her mother didn't leave a will, and to this day it's why Eden and her sister don't speak anymore. They fought over terms. Death without established guidelines, as Shapiro said, causes a lot of family strife.

"At the end, it's kind of sad that money is what we're all mad about," Eden said.

No one wants to talk about money—and they especially don't want to talk about death. That's why, Eden said, her mom didn't leave a will, which is basically a hybrid of the two. But by not thinking or talking about either, she warned, you're doing your family members a huge disservice.

You would think after the mess with her mother, her family would have learned, but it happened again when her father died. Eden was 24 when she found out he hadn't left a will either! Four weeks before he died of brain cancer, Eden said she quickly got a lawyer on the advice of a friend, and she had her father put together a trust for her. During the whole process, she was stressed about the future and grieving her father's imminent death—a surreal combination of emotions she recommended other people avoid.

She started worrying about the estate going to probate court. Probate, according to LegalZoom, is "the legal process through which a deceased person's estate is properly distributed to heirs and designated beneficiaries and any debt